THE NEXT GENERATION

Hemang Joshi, *35*
National president, BJYM

Swadesh Singh, *44*
National secretary

Rituraj Sinha, *47*
Joint coordinator, all cells



BIG SURPRISES

Piyush Goyal, *62*
National treasurer

Tirath Singh Rawat, *62*
National vice-president

Ram Madhav, *61*
National vice-president

Manpreet Singh Badal, *64*
National vice-president

Deepak Mhaskey, *58*
Social media convenor

THE TURNCOATS

Sandeep Pathak, *46*
National secretary



Bharti Pravin Pawar, *47*
National vice-president

Anil Antony, *40*
National secretary

Rohan Gupta, *48*
National secretary

in the 2023 assembly election there, where the latter was election in-charge. Mhaskey is also the first in the post to have come up through the organisation (Malviya and others were lateral entries). Four co-convenors sit alongside him—Priti Gandhi, from Maharashtra, has handled the Mahila Morcha's social media; Shivanand Dwivedi of Delhi is a researcher at the Syama Prasad Mookerjee Research Foundation and a columnist; Alok Bhatt of Uttarakhand has done state-level digital campaigns. The last is Arun Yadav from Haryana, who was removed as the state IT cell chief in July 2022 after a derogatory post on the Prophet from 2017 resurfaced. His return suggests the IT cell's 'reset' is more about reach and distribution than a change of tone.

Party watchers say Nabin's team suggests continuity rather than a break from the past. But in age and gender representation, it has moved the needle. Forty-two of the 64 office-bearers are now below the age of 60 while six of the 13 vice-presidents are women, along with four secretaries and one general secretary—the biggest female presence the national team has ever had.

THE SOUTH SEEMS TO HAVE GOT THE SHORT END OF THE STICK, GETTING JUST SIX BERTHS IN NABIN'S 64-MEMBER TEAM

PREPARING FOR BATTLE

Seven states vote in 2027—UP, Punjab, Uttarakhand, Goa and Manipur early in the year, Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh later. Of these, UP remains the top prize, perhaps why eight appointees are from the state. Nabin's slate maps the state by caste groups against the main opposition Samajwadi Party's PDA (Pichhda, Dalit, Alpsankhyak) formation. So there is Amarpal Maurya, Sangeeta Yadav and Rekha Verma from the OBC cohorts, Harish Dwivedi (Brahmin face) and Irani make it as national general secretaries; three-time MP from Bulandshahr, Bhola Singh, for the Dalits of the west; and also the only two Muslims on the team, former Aligarh Muslim University vice-chancellor Tariq Mansoor (vice-president) and Basit Ali. That Irani, Dwivedi and Verma all lost their seats in 2024 tells you that a grip on party affairs is now valued more than recent electoral form.

With an eye on the Punjab polls, the BJP has elevated Rajya Sabha MP Tarun Chugh to party headquarters in-charge, with added responsibility of Gujarat. Party-hoppers Manpreet Badal (national vice-president) and Sandeep Pathak (national secretary) have also been rewarded. While Chugh and former Aam Aadmi Party man Pathak are electoral strategists of some repute, Manpreet, a former state finance minister, has been losing ground in elections for some years now. His elevation is then possibly a nod at the dominant Jat Sikh community in the state.

The South seems to have got the short end of the stick, accounting for just six faces in the 64-member team. Of these, Kerala has two—veteran Congressman A.K. Antony's son Anil Antony and former state unit chief K. Surendran make it to the national secretaries list. Among the others, D. Purandeswari (Andhra Pradesh) and M. Nagaraja (Karnataka), have been made vice-presidents.

BJP sources say the team is also not entirely the president's. They point to Santhosh, who remains untouchable, Tawde and Bansal, who retain prime positions; and other heavyweights parked in representational tiers. Indeed, Nabin could only manage one secretary for home state Bihar. The bypoll loss in his seat and party stronghold, Bankipur, just weeks ago also possibly weakened his hand. The one unambiguous imprint of the president seems to be the new digital command, but that, too, is still on trial.

Looking forward, it's a momentous time for the BJP and Nabin. Prime Minister Narendra Modi is 75. The NDA government's term runs until 2029. Nabin's own three-year term expires in January 2029, just as the general election campaign begins. But that's getting far ahead in the story. Whether this is a transition or a consolidation might be settled in UP in 2027. A positive verdict will strengthen Nabin's hand, a failure could put him and the party organisation he is building on shaky ground. ■